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Course: 21LEM202T - Universal Human Values - II

Unit – 3 : Session – 1 | Family as the Basic Unit of Human Interaction

Part C — Long-Answer Questions (Solutions)

1. Q1. The family is the basic unit of human interaction because it is the FIRST place where a human being is born, nurtured and educated, and where one first practises relationship. Society is nothing but families joined together, so the quality of society depends on the quality of families. In the family we learn — or fail to learn — the feelings of trust, respect, affection, care, guidance, reverence, glory, gratitude and love. If these feelings are lived in the family, the same person carries them to the workplace and society; if the family is full of conflict, the person carries that conflict outward too. Hence family is the laboratory and foundation of a harmonious society.
2. Q2. The FOUR aspects of relationship are: (1) RECOGNITION — recognising the relationship as it is (this person is my brother, my mother), (2) FULFILMENT — the feelings that flow on the basis of that recognition (trust, respect, affection...), (3) EVALUATION — rightly evaluating myself and the other, and (4) MUTUAL FULFILMENT — the actual result: mutual happiness when feelings are rightly recognised, evaluated and expressed. Relationship is fundamentally in the SELF, not in the body — two bodies can sit together while the selves remain unrelated; it is the feelings in my Self that constitute the relationship.
3. Q3. The NINE feelings (values) in relationship, in order: (1) TRUST (vishwas) — the foundation value, the assurance that the other intends my happiness; (2) RESPECT (sammaan) — right evaluation; (3) AFFECTION (sneh) — the feeling of acceptance of the other as one's own; (4) CARE (mamta) — the feeling of responsibility for nurturing and protecting the other's body; (5) GUIDANCE (vatsalya) — the feeling of responsibility for ensuring the right understanding and right feeling in the other; (6) REVERENCE (shraddha) — acceptance of the excellence of the other; (7) GLORY (gaurav) — the feeling for one who has made effort for excellence; (8) GRATITUDE (kritagyata) — the feeling of acceptance for those who have made effort for my excellence; (9) LOVE (prem) — the feeling of being related to ALL, the complete value. The foundation is TRUST and the complete value is LOVE.
4. Q4. Physical facility (money, gifts, food, gadgets) can fulfil only the needs of the BODY of the other person — it can never substitute for the FEELING in relationship. A father who gives expensive gifts but no time, no trust and no respect leaves the child emotionally deprived; a husband who fills the house with goods but humiliates the wife destroys the relationship. Relationship is fulfilled by feelings in continuity, while physical facility is temporary and quantitative. Feelings like trust and respect can only be generated in the Self through right understanding and expressed in behaviour — no purchase can produce them. So physical facility is necessary for the body, but it is NOT a substitute for feelings.
5. Q5. On reflection, I have mostly related to family members at the level of the BODY — through food, clothes, gifts, outings — and assumed this fulfils the relationship. Examining honestly, the moments of real closeness were those of trust, listening and care — activities of the SELF. When I saw my mother as a co-existence of Self and Body like me, needing respect and understanding as much as I do, my behaviour changed — I argued less and listened more. This confirms that relationship is essentially between two Selves; the body is only the instrument of expression.